



## PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

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### OFFICIAL REPORT

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Correction of errors of substance may be made only on the floor of the House with the permission of the Speaker. However, correction of typographical or grammatical errors which Members suggest for the Bound Volumes which will be compiled at the end of the Meeting may be clearly marked in the Daily Report, and the copy containing the corrections submitted at the Editor's Office, Parliament House, not later than four clear days after the publication of the Daily Report.

BOUND VOLUMES of the Official Report (each with a comprehensive Index) are issued periodically during the Session. There is no fixed subscription rate, but prices will be quoted on each publication.

*Published by Office of Chamber Reporting,  
Parliament House, Accra.*

*Designed and Printed by Publishing Department,  
Parliament House, Accra.*

THE  
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC  
OF GHANA

THIRD MEETING, 2025

Wednesday, 22<sup>nd</sup> October, 2025

*The House met at the Chamber,  
Parliament House, at 2:31 p.m.*

[HON FIRST DEPUTY SPEAKER,  
MR BERNARD AHIAFOR, IN THE  
CHAIR]

**ABSENCE OF THE SPEAKER**

**Deputy Clerk, Information Management Services (IMS) (Mrs Rosemary Arthur-Sarkodie) on behalf of the Clerk to Parliament:** Good afternoon, Hon Members.

Hon Members are kindly informed of the unavoidable absence of the Rt Hon Speaker, and also to note that, in accordance with Order 12 (2) of the Standing Orders of the House, the Hon First Deputy Speaker shall perform the duties and exercise the authority of the Speaker in relation to all proceedings of the House until the Speaker resumes the Chair.

Thank you, Hon Members.

[PRAYERS]

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, we move to the item numbered 5. There is no message from the President and formal communication by the Speaker. So, we would start with correction of *Votes and Proceedings* and the *Official Report*.

**VOTES AND PROCEEDINGS AND  
THE OFFICIAL REPORT**

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I have in my hand the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 21st October, 2025 for correction.

Page 1...4—

Yes, Mr Frank Afriyie?

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, just a little observation. May I kindly crave your indulgence to look at the item numbered 115, “Mahama Alidu Seidu”, the respected Member who just joined us yesterday, is a learned member of the faculty and indeed has earned a title as a professor. And in tune with established conventions of the House, I pray that you direct that same be captured accordingly, if it pleases you.

Mr Speaker, I so submit. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, there are other professors of the House. Look at their names per the *Votes and Proceedings* and tell me where it is indicated Professor or Doctor.

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, with evidence, Professor Nyarko’s professorial title has been captured here appropriately. Likewise, many other Doctors have been captured.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Table Office, take note. Well, I would advise the Hon Member, if you still want your title, then you have to

write to inform the Table accordingly. Because the Table captured what was contained on the writ that was transmitted to Parliament, and they have no authority to add any title to the name, apart from the way it came from the Electoral Commission. So, if you want your title to be used, please notify the Table.

Yes, Hon Laadi Ayii Ayamba?

**Hajia Laadi Ayii Ayamba:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. Although I was present yesterday, I have been captured as absent on page 2.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Table, take note.

Yes, Hon Isaac Ashai Odamtten?

**Mr Isaac Ashai Odamtten:** Mr Speaker, I was also present yesterday and responded to my name when the roll was called. Yet, page 4 which should bear my name, does not.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table, take note. Any further observation up to page 4?

Page 5...7 —

Yes, Hon Isaac Boamah Nyarko?

**Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, the last wording on page 7, under the item numbered 7, we have a by-election which was won by Alidu

Seidu on Tuesday, 23rd September, and “2025” was omitted. If you take the first part on Akwatia which was held on 2nd September, “2025” was captured and there is consistency with the year.

So, I would plead with the House to add “2025” to it.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Table, take note and add “2025” after September.

Yes, Hon Prof Kingsley Nyarko?

**Dr Kingsley Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, thank you for indulging me. With respect, I remember when I received my associate professor title, I had to write. So, the Clerks-at-the-Table are right that my very good friend and former Colleague, Alidu, has to write.

But if we go to page 8, under the item numbered 8, there is Mr Bernard Bediako Baidoo and Prof Alidu Seidu Mahama. So, there should be some form of consistency. We are saying he should write. In another breath, he has been captured as “Prof” here. On page 6, names numbered “55, Godfred Seidu Jasaw; 74, Davis Ansah Opoku; and 85, Mohammed Adams Sukparu”, I remember I saw them here yesterday.

As for Hon Davis Ansah Opoku, he was sitting close to me; he was here. So, I would respectfully submit that their names are deleted from those who were absent and placed under those who were present.

2:41 p.m.

As for Hon Opoku Davis, I am convinced I saw him, but even though I think I saw Hon Sukparu Mohammed Adams and Dr Jasaw Seidu Godfred, we can still check.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table Office, kindly crosscheck.

**Prof Kingsley Nyarko:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. Also, on page 7 under the item numbered 7, the last sentence, “by Alidu Seidu Mahama on Tuesday, 23<sup>rd</sup> September”, we should also include the year “2025”. It was omitted.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That correction has been made by my learned Friend. Table Office, take note.

Page 8...10—

Yes, Hon Isaac Boamah-Nyarko?

**Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

On page 10, under VI, with the spelling of Beijing, China, there is an omission of “g” and if I check, I think Beijing has the letter ‘g’.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** You are right. Table Office, take note.

Yes, Hon Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan?

**Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan:** Mr Speaker, under V, on the same page, it reads, “dated Friday, 19<sup>th</sup> August”. If you

check, Friday was 19<sup>th</sup> September. So, I want to believe they were trying to say 19<sup>th</sup> September, and instead, we have 19<sup>th</sup> August.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, I recall this correction was made yesterday. So, Table Office, take note.

Page 11—

Yes, Hon Rachel Amma Owusuah?

**Ms Rachel Amma Owusuah:** Thank you, Mr Speaker. On page 7, I am Rachel Amma Owusuah, I was present, but my name was omitted.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Table Office, take note.

Page 11—

Yes, Hon Kingsley Nyarko?

**Prof Kingsley Nyarko:** Mr Speaker, page 11, the item numbered 12, “RECOGNITION OF VISITORS”, the numbering, we have “a”, “b”, “b”. So, the third “b” should be deleted, and “c” rather captured.

Again, on the same “c” which reads, “Constituents of Tamale Central, led by Fuseni Yusif. Names have some symbolic meanings. I see Fuseni, F-U-S-E-N-I, but Fuseni should have an “i” after the “e”. I may be wrong, so I would like the Table Office to check if the “i” after “e” was omitted.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Are you talking about the item 12 (c)?

**Prof Kingsley Nyarko:** Yes, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But how come I have the “i”.

**Prof Kingsley Nyarko:** I do not have the “i”.

Mr Speaker, check well, because I have F-U-S-E-N-I. Maybe you are looking at the “i” after “n”. I am talking about “i” after “e”.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, I would just direct the Table Office to cross-check how the name is spelt, whether it is “ei” or not.

Yes, Hon Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan?

**Mr Abdul-Fatawu Alhassan:** Still on page 11, the item numbered 12(a), “Staff and students of Tamale Senior High School from Tamale Central Constituency”. It is supposed to be Sagnarigu Constituency. Tamale Senior High School is in the Sagnarigu Constituency and not Tamale Central.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** You are right. Thank you.

Page 12...15—

Yes, Hon Frank Afriyie?

**Mr Frank Afriyie:** Mr Speaker, thank you so much. Page 15, the item numbered 2 (iv), under attendance, I propose that we delete “Me” and insert “Mr”. I believe it should be “Mr”, but not “Me”. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Table Office, take note.

Page 16.

Hon Members, the *Votes and Proceedings* of Tuesday, 21<sup>st</sup> October, 2025 as presented and corrected is hereby adopted as the true record of proceedings.

Hon Members, we have two *Official Reports*; *Official Report* of 30<sup>th</sup> July, 2025 and the *Official Report* of 31<sup>st</sup> July, 2025. The *Official Report* of 30<sup>th</sup> July, 2025 is under correction. Any corrections?

*[No correction was made to the Official Report of Wednesday, 30<sup>th</sup> July, 2025.]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Now, *Official Report* of 31<sup>st</sup> July, 2025 under correction.

Any correction?

*[No correction was made to the Official Report of Thursday, 31<sup>st</sup> July, 2025.]*

**Mr Ayariga** — rose —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** Mr Speaker—

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu** — rose —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Yes, Hon Habib Iddrisu?

**First Deputy Minority Whip (Alhaji Habib Iddrisu):** Mr Speaker, just before the Majority Leader comes in, I have observed that there are some missing Bills in the *Order Paper*.

Mr Speaker, we had some two Bills under 11(a) on page 3 of the *Order Paper* of yesterday, Tuesday, 21<sup>st</sup> October; the Property Rights of the Spousal Bill, 2025 and then, the Human Sexual Rights and Family Value Bill, 2025.

Mr Speaker, on today's *Order Paper*, the Human Sexual Rights and Family Value Bill 2025, LGBTQ, is confusingly missing in the *Order Paper*. We are aware that this is new to this Parliament, but not new to the House. In the 8th Parliament, we know that the Bill elapsed and that is why yesterday it was reintroduced.

Mr Speaker, speaking with some of the sponsors of the Bill, they indicated that they have satisfied the provisions under Order 186 and they have appeared before the Committee ably chaired by you. We are all aware that before an item can get onto the Order Paper, it means that it might have gone through all the processes and have satisfied the provisions under Order 186, such as Mr Speaker being advised by the Committee and it being sent to the Clerks-at-the-Table. Today, the LGBTQ Bill is missing.

Mr Speaker, it is a serious matter because we cannot have Bills advertised on the *Order Paper* yesterday and the same Bills being missing today without anything being explained to anybody.

We, the Leadership of the Minority are not aware as to why it has not been captured in today's *Order Paper*. Neither of the sponsors of the Bills have been—

Mr Speaker, you know this is a serious matter. I raised an issue last Meeting where two men were kissing at the Independence Square. It is a serious matter, so this LGBTQ Bill cannot be taken out from the *Order Paper*. I do not think my Colleagues from the other Side are now against the LGBTQ Bill, because they were the serious promoters of it; they advocated for it; and they wanted it to be done. So, if it is being introduced, I do not know why it is now missing.

Mr Speaker, even though the Clerks-at-the-Table cannot speak at this point, the Majority Leader is there. It needs to be directed that this Bill needs to be captured because the other Bills have been captured.

2:51 p.m.

The other day, Mr Sam George, Mr Rockson Dafeamekpor and others who were the sponsors and serious advocates of this Bill—Ghana is turning into something else, where we can just see people kissing at Independence Square, men holding hands everywhere and yet we are introducing a Bill into this Parliament and then it has been taken off.

Mr Speaker, I am drawing your attention to this serious issue and that the right thing needs to be done. It should be recaptured as it was captured. Yesterday it had a blend of both Sides. We had

about eight sponsors, such as Rev Ntim Fordjour who had appeared before the Committee under Order 186, and others which included; Mr Sam George, Mr Emmanuel Bedzrah, Ms Helen Ntoso, Alhaji Nurudeen Mumuni, Mr Vincent Ekow Assafuah, Mr Alhassan Tampuli, Ms Rita Naa Odooley Sowah, Dr Tiah Abdul Kabiru and Mr Anthony Mmieh. These were the sponsors of the Bill and it was captured. But now, I do not even understand because even when you look at the sponsors and count the numbers, it appears that the Minority Side are more and have sponsored the Bill more than the Majority Side. So obviously, I do not know why the hypocrisy; whether it is the case that they are now against it. I do not know whether the Majority are now against the Bill.

Mr Speaker, I think this matter needs to be looked at and it needs to be addressed. There must also be an Order Paper Addendum to capture this because the First Reading must be done today. We must take the First Reading today, so you may direct that Order Paper *Addendum* be done to capture this Bill, so that we can be able to make sure that the matter is settled.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Habib, what is Order Paper within our rules?

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker with respect, I am not going to involve myself in an argument or a debate with you. I have raised my concern, addressed my concern and prayed that you direct for an Order Paper Addendum be actually done.

Mr Speaker, with respect to your chair, I will not want to engage in a *tête-à-tête* with you. I will not be involved in that.

Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, yesterday, we observed that some Bills were advertised. They were the Property Rights of Spouses' Bill and then also the Human Sexual Rights and Family Values Bill. At Conclave, we drew the attention of the Rt Hon Speaker to these two Bills that were advertised. The Clerk was there and I think you were also there.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes.

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** So, when we drew the attention of the Rt Hon Speaker to the advertisement, he indicated that he did not recall approving that it should be advertised and the Clerk told me that he thought the Bills had gone through the processes, but The Speaker said, well, he would have to bring him the evidence because he did not recall approving that these two Bills be advertised.

We indicated that we thought that the Bills had been passed by this House already and had been sent to the Presidency for assent, and so we did not see the need to reconsider a Bill that has already been passed by this House waiting for Presidential assent unless the Constitutional procedure for returning the Bill to us is complied with by the President for us to reconsider and then



use our two-thirds Majority to approve the Bill even if the Presidency had some issues with it. So, the Rt Hon Speaker then actually instructed the Clerk to reconsider his action. I believe it is in that spirit that today, the Table Office did not advertise the Bill.

I recall that in relation to the item numbered 1, the Property Rights of Spouses' Bill, the Rt Hon Speaker was actually more disposed towards that because he did recall his decision on that particular one, and then we indicated that Government was also working on a similar issue and therefore there was a need for some engagement so that both the Private Members who were proposing the Bill and the Attorney-General could reconcile positions on the matter and then we could all participate in taking that on board. So, that was the conversation that took place yesterday with the Rt Hon Speaker in the presence of the Clerk. Unfortunately, both of them are not available today. The Speaker has travelled and the Clerk has also travelled, and that is why the Table Office has safely taken it out. But, when the Rt Hon Speaker and the Clerk return, at the level of leadership, we can go and engage him and then agree legally on what the position is. I am saying that — *[Interruption]*—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, I was at the pre-Sitting yesterday.

**Mr Ayariga:** He was there. I am reporting accurately what happened. So, I plead with you, let us—we agreed that

we will try and then transact business expeditiously. Mr Speaker, I would want to vary the Order of Business. — *[Interruption]*— Why are you obstructing me?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, with all due respect, you are not in charge. So, as to whether it is done or not, it is not within your domain.

**Mr Mahama Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I want us to vary the Order of Business and commence public business to present some Papers and then we can then go back to Statements. Mr Speaker, if we may take the item numbered 8 (a) and (b). The Minister for Education is here. He has a very urgent business outside the House but I had to call him to come to lay the Papers so that we can proceed.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Ntim Fordjour, we are talking about matters that happened at pre-Sitting. Were you there?

Yes, Minority Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader, before you come in, Hon Members, with all due respect, pre-Sitting has a reason. Today, I recall that I took the trouble to explain what the Hon Majority Leader had just said to Alhaji Habib Iddrisu; Ms Patricia Appiagyei was there.

We all know that under the new Standing Orders, the procedure for introducing a Private Member's Bill has changed because of the constitutional imperative in Article 108 of the Constitution. At the end of the day, for a Private Member's Bill to be introduced, the Speaker has a say; therefore, if a Private Member's Bill is scheduled on the Order Paper, and the Speaker, who is to give an approval, expresses a dissatisfaction that he has not given an approval to such Bill, and the Clerk admitted that it was done in error, Hon Members, the honourable thing to do is for them to wait until the final approval.

3:01p.m.

Hon Members, the Committee that looked at this Private Member's Bill was chaired by me, and we have written our report to the Speaker. He must look at our report, give consideration to it, and give a go ahead before the Bill can be programmed. I was at the pre-Sitting with the Speaker yesterday, and when the interest was expressed, the Clerk did the honourable thing. This clearly cannot be a matter of debate. So, administrative error can be corrected administratively. Nobody is saying the Bill will not be carried out.

Hon Members, so if this explanation was given at Conclave, this cannot be a subject matter of debate at Plenary.

Hon Members, I intend not to open debate on this matter.

Hon Members, the item numbered 8(b). *[Uproar]*

Yes, Hon Minority Leader, what do you have to say?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, we are in here to accord you every respect. We will assist you in this House.

Mr Speaker, we are in this political act together, and this thing happening today is posterity in action. I was there. When we were in government, our friends knew the views of stakeholders in the governance of this country on this matter, and they were clear in their ambush. Now, the chickens have come home to roost. Only yesterday, when we were raising this issue, they were saying that the Bill must pass. Now, they are in government and are in the hot seat.

When the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the World Bank, the Inter-Parliamentary Union (IPU) threatened it, they are now running away. They are saying it is procedure; which mistake? There was nothing administratively in error. I dare say for the record. They forced the LGBT on the throat of the Akufo-Addo Government. Today, they do not want LGBT. They would want it. *Mo be pe papapapapa!—[Laughter]*—They used it to win elections. Now that the stakeholders and the international community is warning them, they want to run away. Run to where? They now see governance. They are in the kitchen and they can feel the heat. I was there; we pleaded with them to let us manage the situation yet they said no. Do they remember that hot afternoon? Mr Agbodza, as a Chief Whip, do they remember that hot afternoon? When they

suffocated me with Third Reading—  
They are laughing. *Mo be pe papapapa!*

Mr Speaker, this Bill, —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** What is the meaning of what you said?  
[Laughter]

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Sometimes when I look at the Hon Majority Leader— Hon Majority Leader, it is not easy.

Mr Speaker, what I am trying to tell them is that, when they were in opposition, they forced this Bill on us. Even when it was in court, they said the Bill must be signed into law. We heard His Excellency President Mahama when he said he has seen the Bill but he is referring it to the Attorney-General, and this was in January. Then they would look at— the very clauses, the aspect of criminalising, bringing a conviction and sentencing where the person must suffer a jail term. The very thing that they wanted, he said, they would have to look at it and change it.

Mr Speaker, today, —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Minority Leader?

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, with respect, let me land—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But do not forget that—

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, stay away from this debate. Let us finish—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** At the material time that this Bill was being considered, I was the Ranking Member for Constitutional, Legal and Parliamentary Affairs, and I recall that the Bill that was passed had nothing criminal. We took out the criminal element at the Committee sitting—

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, no, with respect, let me help. Let me refresh our memory. I was the Leader of Government Business, and I brought an amendment and it was rejected.

Mr Speaker, the Bill was suffocating Government at the time. We were in a difficult situation, and we pleaded with our Colleagues that we should manage this situation. They said no. Today, they are in government, and they have realised that they do not need LGBT. This is like a scorpion sitting on a Shivling. That LGBT scorpion, they place it on that Shivling. Whether they like it or not, they would like it. Hon Majority Leader, stay away from this matter. Mr Speaker, he has had his bite and it is all right. The Hon Majority Leader says that the Speaker and the Clerk to Parliament are not around. I would oblige you. *Na Sasabonsam koraaa y3 nhy3 no 1000 years koraa eso y3.* Mr Speaker will come next week.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** But you are offending our rules.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, I am explaining.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Whatever you say, you have to translate.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** Mr Speaker, to wit, even if we give them thousand years, thousand years will come.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

**Osahen Afenyo-Markin:** So, Leader of Government Business, it is all right. What does he want to say again? He wants to vary the Order? He supported it. He was their Chief Legal Advisor. He supported it. Now they are running away. Mr Speaker, it is all right. The Speaker will come next week. Rev. Ntim Fordjour, definitely next week will come. God will give us life. Whether they like it or not, they will pass that Bill, and they can use their super Majority to reject it.

The Minister for Education needs grants. He needs foreign aid. He needs support for his Ministry. Now, do they like LGBT or not? He is vying for running mate. Does he like LGBT or not? Say it. Let us hear him on record. The Minister for Education wants a woman to be a President and possibly, he will be the Vice President, does he want LGBT? Say it. What is his position? The Minister for Education should declare his position. *[Uproar]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, the track record of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) in this matter is very clear. *[Interruption]*

Mr Speaker, history will bear testimony that as far back as when the late President John Evans Atta-Mills, and the United Kingdom Government tried to get us favourable toward certain legislation,

3:11 p.m.

We resisted; we rejected and stood our ground. I can assure you and every Ghanaian that under the watch of the National Democratic Congress (NDC) government, this practice will not be allowed. *[Uproar]*

I am saying that under the watch of the NDC government, this practice will not be allowed. Mr Speaker, so far as I am concerned, even when we were a Minority, we succeeded in passing this Bill, and so far as the records will bear it, the Bill has been passed. All that we are saying is that, so far as we are concerned, this House passed the Bill. This House passed the Bill— *[Interruption]*. But I have just said it, that this House passed the Bill.

Mr Speaker, we will wait for the Speaker to return and give directions in this matter.

Mr Speaker, I crave your indulgence; If we can take item 8 (b).

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, item numbered 8 (b).

## PAPERS

*By the Minister for Education —*

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the St. Teresa's College of Education for the year 2024.

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Al-Faruq College of Education for the year 2024.

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Tamale Technical University for the year 2024.

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the St. John Bosco's College of Education, Navrongo for the year 2024.

*Referred to the Committee on Education.*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Chairman, let us take item numbered 8 (a), the Hon Minister is here.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Item numbered 8(a), Minister for Energy and Green Transition.

## PAPER

*By the Minister for Energy and Green Transition (Mr John Abdulai Jinapor) —*

Petroleum Agreement among the Government of the Republic of

Ghana (represented by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition) and Ghana National Petroleum Corporation (GNPC), GNPC Exploration and Production Limited Company (Explorco) and Tristar Upstream Oil and Gas Limited (Tristar) for the exploration, development and production operations in the Ghana Western Basin Block 1 (GH\_WB\_01).

*Referred to the Committee on Energy.*

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is not immediately available, so I crave your indulgence if the Minister for Energy and Green Transition could lay the Report of the Human Rights Commission on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minority Leader?

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice cannot be busy more than the Chamber. This morning, he had a press conference. Everyday press conference, but he cannot come to the Chamber to prosecute his own Business? They must bring the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice to lay the Paper. So, for that one—Mr Speaker, there are other things that we can do. Let us do the Business of those who are here. Call the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice. He should come here. He has finished his press conference, so he should come here and do the right thing.

**Mr Ayariga:** I see that the press conferences of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is really worrying you. *[Laughter]* Please, can we just lay his Report?

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Minister for Energy and Green Transition. You may do so.

### PAPER

*By the Minister for Energy and Green Transition (Mr John Abdulai Jinapor) on behalf of the Attorney-General and Minister for Justice—*

Annual Statement by the Audit Committee of the Commission on Human Rights and Administrative Justice (CHRAJ).

*Referred to the Committee on Constitutional Bodies.*

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker if we can take item numbered 8 (d).

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Item numbered 8 (d).

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, the Majority Leader can do it on behalf of the Chairman of the Committee.

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, Item numbered 8(d), I will lay it on behalf of the Committee.

### PAPER

*By the Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga) on behalf to the Chairman of the Committee —*

Report of the Ad Hoc Committee to consider the establishment of a Pension Scheme for Members of Parliament.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Majority Leader?

**Mr Ayariga:** Mr Speaker, I think for today, that is all. But yesterday, you agreed to allow Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlins to make a Statement on maritime security. Mr Speaker, she is here, so if we can go back to Statements.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. Hon Members, item numbered 6, Statements.

Before then, indulge me to acknowledge our revered students visiting us today. We have Grace Field Basic School, led by Ms Regina Efu, an Administrator and they are from Adentan Constituency. They are 80 in number.

*[Pupils of Grace Field Basic School were acknowledged]*

We also have Akronso M/A Basic School, led by Mr Ntifo Cephas, the Head Teacher. They are from Abuakwa South. They are 63 in number.

*[Pupils of Akronso M/A Basic School were acknowledged]*

On behalf of Parliament of the Republic of Ghana, you are most welcome. May you have a fruitful visit to Parliament of Ghana. You may resume your seats.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, I have in my hands a Statement or a tribute to the late Hon Lawyer Alfred Kwame Agbesi, former Member of Parliament for Ashaiman Constituency. It would be taken by Hon Dr Ernest Henry Norgbey.

Hon Member, you have the Floor.

3.21 p.m.

## STATEMENTS

### **Tribute to the Late Hon Lawyer Alfred Kwame Agbesi, Former MP for Ashaiman**

**Dr Ernest Henry Norgbey (NDC — Ashaiman):** With a heavy heart and deep sense of loss, I rise to pay tribute to a remarkable son of the Ashaiman Constituency, a distinguished lawyer, an exemplary legislator, a faithful servant of the people, and above all, a man whose life radiated kindness, humility and devotion to the service of humanity, the Late Hon Lawyer Alfred Kwame Agbesi. As I stand in the shoes he once filled, I am humbled by the weight of his legacy and the magnitude of his contributions to this Constituency and our beloved nation.

Born with a passion for justice and humanity, Hon Agbesi lived a purposeful life anchored on service, empathy, and fairness. As a lawyer, he carried his profession with dignity and used it as a tool for social transformation. As a politician, he gave meaning to leadership by listening to the people, standing with the vulnerable, and representing Ashaiman

with unyielding commitment to progress and peace.

Hon Agbesi served three terms as a Member of Parliament for the good people of Ashaiman on the ticket of the National Democratic Congress (NDC). Throughout his years in this august House, he distinguished himself as a principled, calm, and thoughtful legislator who placed national interests above partisanship. His contributions to debates were always marked by insight, legal depth, and unpretentious desire to make laws that uplifted the living conditions of ordinary Ghanaians.

Hon Agbesi's parliamentary career was marked by a significant milestone that brought honour to Ashaiman and Ghana. He served with distinction as Deputy Majority Leader of the Sixth Parliament under the John Dramani Mahama Administration, demonstrating exceptional leadership in steering the legislative agenda of this House. His wisdom and counsel were sought after by Colleagues across party lines. Beyond our national borders, he represented Ghana in Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS) Parliament in 2009 and 2013, contributing his voice to regional discussions that shaped West Africa's future.

He was a firm believer in the ideals of democracy, development, and social justice. In Committees, he worked with diligence and decorum; in Plenary, he spoke with clarity and conviction. Hon Agbesi was never loud, yet his words carried weight. He was never confrontational, yet his presence commanded respect. His

Colleagues on both Sides of the aisle admired him for his calm disposition, his sense of humour, and his ability to bring people together even in moments of heated political divisions.

But beyond politics, Hon Agbesi was a man of the people, a father, a mentor, a friend and a listening leader. He was deeply loved by the people of Ashaiman because he lived among them, shared in their joys and burdens and gave selflessly of what he had. His door was always opened; his hand was always extended to help. Whether it was struggling students seeking assistance, a widow in need of comfort, or a youth yearning for direction, Hon Agbesi made everyone feel seen, heard, and valued. He was in every sense a bridge builder between the young and old, the rich and poor, the political and the ordinary. His humility endeared him to all and his generosity became a lifeline for many. Indeed, his legacy in Ashaiman will forever be remembered, not only in the projects he championed or the development initiatives he led, but in the countless lives he touched with compassion and sincerity.

Mr Speaker, the people of Ashaiman have lost a father figure. The National Democratic Congress has lost a loyal stalwart. Ghana has lost a fine gentleman whose patriotism, discipline, and sense of duty reflected the best of our democratic values. Yet, even in our sorrow, we celebrate the fullness of his life, a life lived for others, a journey marked by service and a faith anchored in hope. The late Hon Alfred Agbesi leaves behind an enduring example that

leadership is not about power or titles, but about humility, humanity, and heart.

Mr Speaker, as we bid farewell to Hon Lawyer Alfred Kwame Agbesi, we do not merely mourn a political leader, we celebrate a life beautifully lived in service to others. As his successor, and as one of the many who benefited from his wisdom and mentorship, I stand here today to say, “Ashaiman remembers you, Ghana honours you, your legacy lives on.”

To his beloved family, we extend our deepest condolences. May they find comfort in the knowledge that Hon Agbesi's labour or love was not in vain. His footprints are deeply engraved in the story of Ashaiman, in the records of Parliament, and in the hearts of all who knew him.

Mr Speaker, in the words of the Apostle Paul, “I have fought the good fight, I have finished the race, I have kept the faith.”. Indeed, Hon Alfred Kwame Agbesi fought well, served well and loved deeply. May his gentle soul rest in perfect peace. Farewell Hon Alfred Kwame Agbesi, servant of the people, friend of Ashaiman, and faithful son of Ghana.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. I will then open the floor for comments. Yes, Hon Bedzrah?

**Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity and also let



me thank my Colleague, Hon Ernest Norgbey, the Member of Parliament for Ashaiman, for this tribute.

Mr Speaker, in 2009, when we came to this House, we met the late Hon Alfred Agbesi, whom we all know hails from the Volta Region, but is a Member of Parliament for the people of Ashaiman, as well as the good people of the Greater Accra Region.

Mr Speaker, one remarkable thing about the late Hon Agbesi was the fact that he was a jovial person; he did not take things to heart at all. When there was an issue, he would want us to resolve it once and for all. Even though he was a Member of Parliament for the good people of Ashaiman, he did not forget about his roots of being from the Volta Region, more especially from the South Tongu district. When he decided not to run again and left, we were thinking that because he was a very experienced person, being the Deputy Majority Leader at that time, and a lawyer of course, he could come and serve in the South Tongu area of the Volta Region. But when we approached him, he told us point-blank that, “I have done my best for this nation and it is time for me to rest”.

Mr Speaker, Hon Agbesi, we all know, especially those of us who met him here in 2009, has credited himself very well. There was no scandal on Hon Agbesi. One could go to him as the Deputy Majority Leader in his office, and he was open to receiving us, especially, we the young ones, and he led us on what to do in the House.

We have lost a great man, the party has lost an astute politician, and Ghana has indeed, lost a Member who credited himself well in this Chamber.

On that note, Mr Speaker, I thank you so much and I wish the families well. We will all be there on Saturday to bid him farewell.

Thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much, Hon Bedzrah.

Hon Members, I then move to take a Statement, standing in the name of Hon Dr Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings.

Hon Member, you have the floor.

3.31 p.m.

### **Piracy, Maritime Crime, and Maritime Domain Awareness, and the Domestication of UNCLOS**

**Dr Zanetor Agyemang-Rawlings (NDC — Klottey Korle):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to make a Statement on piracy, maritime crime, and maritime domain awareness, and the need to domesticate United Nation Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS).

Today, I rise to make a Statement to draw the attention of this august House to the growing threat posed by piracy and maritime crime in the Gulf of Guinea, the urgent need to strengthen our maritime domain awareness, and the critical importance of reforming legislature and institutional coordination in protecting

Ghana's territorial waters and strategic interests, including the blue economy.

The year 2023 marked a decade since the signing of the Yaoundé Code of Conduct. It is a regional framework developed to prevent and suppress illegal maritime activities in the region, and in general, enhance maritime security in West and Central Africa. Ghana is part of the sub-region Zone F under this framework, which also includes Côte d'Ivoire, Liberia, Sierra Leone, Guinea, and Burkina Faso. Zone F is managed by the Multinational Maritime Coordination Centre (MMCC) with its headquarters located in Accra, precisely, the Christiansborg Castle, Osu, in the Klottey Korle constituency, which I have the honour of representing in this House.

Mr Speaker, despite Ghana's prominent position, our domestic legislative and institutional framework remain inadequate to match the scale and complexity of the maritime crime threat, which has transnational dimensions to it, and also a direct impact on our national security. Some of the challenges Ghana faces are as follows: Ghana has still not completely domesticated UNCLOS, the principal international legal framework for maritime governance; the definition of piracy under Section 193 of the Criminal Offences Act, 1960, (Act 29), is inconsistent with the Article 101 of UNCLOS, which has resulted in our inability to successfully prosecute acts of piracy under our laws; lack of clear regulations and sanctions in place to address issues of crime at anchorage, especially, since Ghana is both a coastal and a port state; Ghana does not currently

have a standalone maritime offences law, the absence of which means that prosecuting for piracy and other maritime crimes is hampered by our ability to respond swiftly and effectively, but it also undermines our commitments under international law.

Maritime insecurity arises from: increased transnational organised crime; illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing; environmental crimes and environmental degradation; disappearing biodiversity and effects of climate change, to name a few.

Some of the maritime crimes include piracy, armed robbery at sea, illegal, unreported and unregulated fishing, drug trafficking, human trafficking, oil bunkering and smuggling, and this requires harmonised legal responses across various jurisdictions. Without the domestication of UNCLOS and other relevant instruments, Ghana remains vulnerable to these offences and prolonged legal proceedings that benefit perpetrators of crime.

Mr Speaker, piracy and maritime crime have direct and tangible impact on Ghana's economy and the wellbeing of our citizens. One of the most significant but often overlooked effect is the elevated cost of maritime insurance premiums for vessels traversing the Gulf of Guinea. Because of our maritime corridor, which is considered a high-risk zone, shipping companies are charged higher insurance rates. These costs are ultimately transferred to the Ghanaian consumers in the form of higher prices for imported goods, including food, fuel,

machinery and pharmaceuticals. Mr Speaker, in order words, the insecurity in our waters is quietly taxing every household in Ghana. This means that the cost of living is indirectly inflated, due to our inability to fully secure our maritime domain. If we are serious about improving our economy and protecting our borders, we must equally be serious about maritime security.

Mr Speaker, another area that deserves attention is the disconnect between the Yaoundé Code of Conduct and fishing communities. There is a pressing need for greater inclusion, awareness creation and sensitivity at the grassroots level. Maritime domain awareness must not be limited to the corridors of power or security sector alone. It must extend to coastal communities who are both stakeholders and unfortunately sometimes vulnerable to recruitment by criminal networks.

Finally, let us not forget that maritime crimes begin and end on land. The nexus between maritime crime and border transnational threats, including terrorism and organised crime, cannot be ignored. As such, maritime security is not just a naval issue, it is a national security issue.

Mr Speaker, in light of these realities, I would like to recommend some of the urgent strategic actions that this House, courtesy of the Minister of Transport, in collaboration with the relevant ministries, departments or agencies, submits to the House a Bill that will pave the way for the repeal of our current outdated piracy laws and ensure that Ghana is fully

compliant with UNCLOS and aligned with regional and global efforts to tackle maritime crime. In the course of my research enquiries about this statement, I have also learned that steps are being taken to that effect and that Cabinet has given approval for the Bill to be laid. I urge the Minister to do so as soon as practical and urge members of the House to support this bill when it comes before the House.

I also urge the Government to consider establishing a fund financed through a portion of port charges to support maritime security enforcement and operations, technological upgrades, community engagement and coastal surveillance infrastructure. Coastal fishing communities should, in collaboration with traditional leaders and coastal communities, be formally integrated into the national maritime security strategy of the country. This can be via training programmes, community-based reporting systems and economic alternatives for vulnerable coastal youth.

Furthermore, I would like to urge the Government to embark on intensive awareness campaigns on the dangers of maritime crime, the importance of legal fishing practices and the economic value of a secure maritime domain.

Finally, to urge the implementation of the National Integrated Maritime Strategy and its implementation plan that were adopted a few years ago. They provide a very good framework for addressing maritime security and ocean governance in general.

Mr Speaker, the time has come for Parliament to show leadership in this area. Let us prioritise the necessary legal reforms and work across the aisle to protect Ghana's economic interests, especially our blue economy, territorial integrity, and the safety of our people.

In conclusion, our maritime domain is not just a frontier; it is a source of trade, energy, nutrition and sovereignty. If we are to secure Ghana's future, we must secure our maritime domain. Let us demonstrate leadership in this House through legislative reform, oversight and a collective sense of urgency in rising to meet this challenge.

Mr Speaker, thank you for the opportunity.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, Statements ably made, it is now for your comments. The floor is now opened.

Hon Members, in the absence of any comment, I have another Statement standing in the name of Charles Forson; Mr Charles Forson, you have the floor.

### **Designated One-Hour Slot for Backbenchers' Business**

**Mr Charles Forson (NPP — Tema Central):** Mr Speaker, thank you.

I rise in my capacity as Chairman of the Committee on the Backbenchers' Business to make the Statement in respect of the one-hour slot provided under Order 73 of our Standing Orders for the concentration on Backbenchers'

Business on the last Wednesday of every month.

Mr Speaker, the inclusion of the Backbenchers' Time in our Standing Orders represents a significant milestone in strengthening parliamentary democracy and promoting inclusiveness in our deliberations. It acknowledges that Members of Parliament who are Backbenchers can shape the national discourse by bringing forward matters of public interest, constituency concern and all legislative importance for debate in this honourable House.

As the British political scientist Philip Cowell rightly said, "allowing backbenchers some influence at Westminster is more than just when they speak; it is also getting the topics they want on the agenda when they want them on the agenda." This insight underscores the very essence of the concept of Backbenchers' Business in our Standing Orders.

3:41 p.m.

Mr Speaker, it is not merely about offering Backbenchers an opportunity to speak, but also empowering them to shape the parliamentary agenda, ensuring that voices, priorities and realities of constituents across the country find deliberate space in the Business of the House.

Mr Speaker, the Committee on Backbenchers' Business was established to facilitate the process by determining the business of backbenchers for each Meeting, proposing the Business for

backbenchers' time and the order in which the Business shall be taken, and in consultation with the Business Committee, present to the House for consideration a Statement on Backbenchers' Business. Although the Committee is yet to fully operationalise its mandate, the Committee has been laying the groundwork to activate this important provision. Preparatory work is ongoing to establish the structures and modalities that will enable meaningful participation by all Members in Backbenchers' Business.

Mr Speaker, given the nature of the parliamentary calendar before us, the Committee recognises that opportunities to schedule Backbenchers' Business this year are limited. However, the Committee is exploring the possibility of using October and November to pilot two backbench debates, in consultation with Leadership and the Business Committee. This will serve as an important step towards demonstrating how Backbenchers' Business can enrich our deliberations, reflect public priorities and deepen the culture of inclusive decision-making. The Committee will, in the meantime, continue to develop its operational roadmap and visibility strategy under the theme, "Backbench Matters", to guide its full activation in the next Session.

Mr Speaker, the Committee therefore encourages all Backbenchers to prepare and submit proposals for possible consideration as Backbenchers' Business in upcoming Sittings. In doing so, we will be affirming Parliament's commitment to inclusivity, deliberation and the strengthening of democratic governance.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, I wish to assure this House that the Committee on Backbenchers' Business remains committed to delivering on its mandate. We look forward to working collaboratively with Leadership and all Members to make Backbench Business a vibrant, meaningful, impactful and respected part of our parliamentary practice.

Mr Speaker, I once again thank you.  
*[Hear! Hear!]*

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much, Hon Member. It is now for Members' comments.

**Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama (NPP — Walewale):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. The Chairman of the Committee on Backbenchers' Business, a newly established Committee of Parliament brings to the fore certain important matters that are not just affecting the Backbenchers but also the aura of this whole House.

Mr Speaker, a House that has many Backbenchers or many first timers, the use of the word, "Backbenchers" has always been associated with timidity, newness and lack of competence. It is so unfortunate to note that the Hon Member for Mion and Nanton nearly lost their seats by way of by-election when they reported that they were members of the Committee on Backbenchers' Business because it brought a lot of public debate in the Northern Region that their Members, for the first time in Parliament, were not given any Committee but were made members of

the Committee on Backbenchers' Business.

Mr Speaker, it is the perception of the people outside the House that the Committee on Backbenchers' Business is meant for people who do not have the capacity to participate in debate which is far from the truth. We will need to rebrand this Committee on Backbenchers' Business and that is essentially what the leader of the Committee is doing.

Mr Speaker, there are important issues that we need to face. The time allocated for Backbenchers should not just be that time, but Backbenchers should make conscious effort to catch the eye of the Speaker. For instance, the Hon Member for Binduri is at the far end and without conscious effort, you will not recognise him. The newly-elected Member for Tamale Central, Prof Alidu Seidu, is behind the pillar and without conscious effort, you will not recognise him. The new Member for Akwatia—Our Colleague, Ernest, was even better because he was sitting right behind me but Prof Seidu is sitting right behind the pillar so, without conscious effort, you will not recognise him. Mr Speaker, there is a need for there to be conscious effort in recognising Backbenchers.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Member, do you mean to say sitting behind the pillar or wall?

**Dr Mahama:** Mr Speaker, I corrected that by saying behind the pillar. *[Laughter]* As a matter of fact, he is within the walls of Parliament, but he is sitting behind the pillar. So, thank you

very much for that. I thought that was what Hon Bedzrah wanted to correct.

Mr Speaker, the time allocated for Backbenchers or the Business of Backbenchers must be resourced for the Backbenchers to be able to contribute meaningfully to the debate of this House. There is a lot of capacity. The newcomers of this House have so much fire in their bellies, capacity and talent they would want to unleash. But without opportunity given to them, they will not be able to show to the good people of Ghana what they have in store. So, I am just urging this House that the Statement read by the Leader of the Backbenchers Committee should be taken seriously and consequential direction be made so that that Committee to be established, that secretariat, would be engaging regularly. For instance, we can organise orientation for our newcomers, our juniors who have just come.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Did you say the Committee should be established?

**Dr Mahama:** Mr Speaker, I said the Committee intends establishing a secretariat.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well.

**Dr Mahama:** And that secretariat has to be resourced to be able to do the work as expected. Mr Speaker, with these few words, I want to thank the Leader of the Backbenchers for the brilliant Statement and to say that the perception that Backbenchers are

associated with incompetence, that my Hon Colleague from Mion went through, be done away with. They are very capable Members of Parliament, Mr Speaker. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Very well. I will give the floor to Hon Bedzrah.

**Mr Emmanuel Kwasi Bedzrah (NDC — Ho West):** Thank you, Mr Speaker. Let me commend the Chairperson of the Backbencher's Caucus who made a Statement on behalf of the Members of the Backbenchers and also for the fact that this Parliament has established a caucus called the Backbenchers' Caucus.

Mr Speaker, this is for an illustration and for education of the public. Order 6 of our Standing Orders states that:

“Backbencher means a Member who has served not more than two Parliamentary terms and is not a Minister of State, part of Leadership of the House or Leadership of a Committee except the Chairperson or Ranking Member of the Backbenchers' Committee.”

Mr Speaker, clearly, it is not for first timers. The Backbench is for those who have even served more than once and are here for the second time. They are not either with the extended leadership, that is, Chairman, Ranking Members, Deputy or not. One can be here for two terms and still be a Backbencher. Backbencher is a terminology coined; we all read *Erskine May*. It is simply to identify a group of people as has been identified by this.

Mr Speaker, Order 236 talks about Backbenchers and states clearly:

“(1) The Committee on Backbenchers' Business comprises a Chairperson, a Ranking Member, a Vice Chairperson, a Deputy Ranking Member who are Backbenchers and not more than thirteen other Backbenchers.

(2) The Committee shall

- (a) determine the business of Backbenchers for each Meeting;
- (b) propose the business for Backbenchers Time and the order in which the business shall be taken; and
- (c) in consultation with the Business Committee, present to the House for consideration, a statement on Backbenchers business.”

3:51 p.m.

Clearly, this Parliament has given enough power to Members of the Committee on Backbenchers' Business. You have time that you can even make Statements. You can bring issues of public interest and that is solely limited to Backbenchers. And those of us who are here for more than three terms will not even have an opportunity to contribute.

Mr Speaker, it should be known to all of us that being a Backbencher is not a sin. It is not derogatory and has nothing

to do with anybody at all. It is just like when we also came, we have been here for the first, second, third, fourth and fifth terms and some are here for the sixth term. So, if you are here for the first and second terms, try and join the Backbenchers' Caucus because it will do you a lot of good.

Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Mr Boamah-Nyarko?

**Mr Isaac Boamah-Nyarko:** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker.

Mr Speaker, let me commend the Chairperson of the Committee on Backbenchers' Business for bringing this issue to the fore. Mr Speaker, when we came into this House the very first time, we realised that the Standing Orders has given a lot of clarity on the scope of the Committee on Backbenchers' Business, what it is supposed to do by way of building capacity and training young MPs, and give us the opportunity to express ourselves and contribute positively to the Business of the House.

Mr Speaker, my senior Colleague, Mr Emmanuel Bedzrah, has given some perspective as to the composition of the Committee on Backbenchers' Business. And if, as he clearly read, we have Backbenchers consisting of first and second timers, then the impression that Backbenchers are solely first timers is to be corrected. And I think he has made that very clear.

But more importantly, it is for good reason that the House created what we call the Backbenchers' Time. The Backbenchers' Time, as we read from Order 6 of the Standing Orders says that:

“Backbenchers' Time means a time set aside for Backbenchers to make Statements, present Petitions, move Motions, or initiate Private Member's Bill.”

So clearly, these are some of the things or the opportunities that are given to Backbenchers.

My difficulty has been how Leadership, and if I say Leadership, I mean the Leader of Government Business, has not done much in ensuring that the business of Backbenchers is taken into consideration and addressed. If you look at Order 73, it says that:

“The House shall allot one hour on the last Wednesday of a month for the consideration of determined business for Backbenchers.”

So clearly, the standing orders have made provision as to when the Backbenchers' Time is allotted. How many months have we been in this Chamber? That specific last Wednesday time for Backbenchers' business has not been observed. And it is because reasonably, either the Business of the House is overwhelming, or we have not really seen this provision that is made under this Backbenchers' Time as an opportunity to build up the capacity and the strength of Backbenchers.



Mr Speaker, I think from this Statement that the Chairperson of the Committee on Backbenchers' Business has brought to the fore, we are going to look actively at it more closely. As Mr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama has indicated, in this House, we have Leadership, we have senior Members, and we have Backbenchers. So as much as possible, we will be looking forward to the Rt Hon Speaker allowing Backbenchers a little more flexibility. We learn in the course of our engagement in this House. We make mistakes, and then it is on the part of the Rt Hon Speaker and Leadership to guide and build Members from the Backbench, so that reasonably over time, we would all have the ability to do the work and be strong and contribute meaningfully to the Business of this House.

Mr Speaker, in conclusion, it is my hope that the time allotted for Backbenchers as stipulated in our Standing Orders, effective this Third Meeting, would be looked at seriously. We would commit ourselves to it. We would push the Leadership of our Committee to engage the Business Committee to make sure that in the course of every month, at least, the business of Backbenchers is provided for. There is clarity as to what we are going to do on that day, and then we build a better and a stronger Parliament, starting from the Backbench.

With these few words, Mr Speaker, I want to thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much. Yes, Hon Minister for Education?

I will come to you, Hon Minister for Energy and Green Transition.

**Minister for Education (Mr Haruna Iddrisu):** Mr Speaker, I want to thank you for the opportunity to contribute to the Statement made by Mr Charles Forson, asking for the Backbenchers' Day.

Mr Speaker, I would like to remind us that all of us entered this House as Backbenchers. Your day of entry is the day you emerged, having been elected as Member of Parliament. Mr Speaker, in Parliamentary Practice, we are told, throughout the world, is based on experience. That is why it is my wish that every Backbencher will have an opportunity to rise through the ranks, through the Middle Bench, even to the Front Bench and to lead. But they can only lead if we give them an opportunity to learn.

However, Mr Speaker, they themselves must be ready to learn. And when we say they must be ready to learn, in particular for Ghana, there are two important things: Is the Member of Parliament familiar with the provisions of the 1992 Constitution? Yes, they must be. If for nothing at all, from Article 106 to 124, every Member of Parliament must keep it in memory. If they are that kind of Member like Mr Samuel Abu Jinapor, then they can add the chapters on fundamental human rights and freedoms, because Parliament is the guardian of those rights and freedoms. In a country where there is rule of law, that would be the most fundamental thing. That is why this House must be worried

and concerned, at all times, when the right and freedom of any person is infringed upon, because that is the gravest threat to the practice of democracy.

But, Mr Speaker, in discussing Backbenchers' Day, I am happy your Clerks-at-the-Table are here. This House must improve upon our own practice.

I recall, Mr Speaker, your good self, were in the meeting in Akosombo when we went through a long period from—I should pay respect to the Mr Papa Owusu-Ankomah, Mr Yieleh Chireh, and the rest, when they said that Parliament must change its Standing Orders. I recall, Mr Speaker, in one of the meetings in which you were, I contested, but I was defeated. Today, I am honoured. I kept telling them to declare a Minority Day in the Standing Orders of this House. And that, that day must be solely reserved as a Minority Day, because, Mr Speaker, the best way to enrich democracy is to have the views of the other Side, the opposite Side of the aisle.

I recall, Mr Speaker, I had travelled with one of you to the French National Assembly, and the Sri Lankan and Indian Assemblies with Mr Osei Kyei-Mensah-Bonsu, and I even brought a book to this Parliamentary Review Committee. There was a book written by one of the authorities on rules and procedure. And I drew Parliament's attention that we should declare a Minority Day, a day the Minority can move a Motion. Mr Speaker, you would again recall that I came here with you after we left school.

You remember my popular *adumdum adumdum be gyae*? It was a Motion. [**An Hon Member:** *adumdum adumdum*]*—be gyae*.

4:01 p.m.

He was here with the Hon Kan Dapaah, Buckman and co. So, Backbenchers Day, Mr Speaker, we need to have a dedicated time for the political opposition to make constructive alternatives, not just commentary.

Mr Speaker, I have said it repeatedly that the day the Parliament of Ghana sits right, the Ghanaian people will smile. Because a lot of the wrongs in this country are because Parliament sits and allows it. Why are we having problems with debt? Forgive me, Mr Speaker, but I heard President Nana Addo Dankwa in Brussels lamenting about excessive borrowing and what that exchange has done to him. The darkest hour. How did the dark hour happen? Because the Parliament of Ghana failed to limit and remind him that, yes, he has the powers, but he should not borrow excessively.

The Hon Member may disagree. I know he is a special aid, but Mr Speaker, I wholeheartedly support that we give Backbenchers an opportunity.

Then finally, Mr Speaker, my comment, which had you personally concerned. When they bring reports to this Chamber, how many Backbenchers or even Frontbenchers want to read the reports? Please, when they bring reports, do we go through the reports in order to understand what is in the reports? So,

Backbenchers must be ready to learn, and to learn is easy; master the Standing Orders.

Sometimes, Mr Speaker, when I see Leaders in front shouting, that is not for Leaders to do. If one is a good Leader, one must have those who do that for them. I saw them a while ago talking about LGBTQ and Hon Habib—Interesting times in Ghana. He was in Ghana when Parliament passed the law. Nana Addo Dankwa was in breach of the Constitution, and he did not have the voice—Read Article 106 (7) and (8), he was in breach. If Parliament gives a Bill to the President, he can decide to give assent or not, and the Constitution provides what he should do. Did he do that? Then they allow it to lapse, and today we are discussing the same matter.

I heard the Leader say there was no administrative error, but there was a constitutional error. The Constitution is elaborate. What does one do? It is not to say that President Akufo-Addo cannot disagree with Parliament. But if he disagrees, he should convey it back to Parliament that he disagrees, and give his reason—*[Interruption]*. We should pass it? I simply would have ended by saying, why did they not pass it? But it will be passed. Thank you.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, former Minister for Lands and Natural Resources?

**Mr Samuel Abdulai Jinapor (NPP—Damongo):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to contribute to this very important subject.

I must confess that when I first had the privilege of coming into this House in 2021, I was also at a loss as to what constitutes a Backbencher. It appears that the framers of our Standing Orders, from Order 1 to 6, with the heading, “Interpretation”, have attempted to define what constitutes a Backbencher.

Mr Speaker, the relevant provisions have been copiously quoted, and I do not intend to repeat. But it is clear that our Parliament equates a Backbencher, from the interpretation, to tenor of office. How many terms has one been in Parliament? Mr Speaker, the Hon Minister for Education and MP for Tamale South talks about alternative ways of formulating our Standing Orders. And I want to say, Mr Speaker, that part of the problem I believe we have is the very definition of who constitutes a Backbencher.

Mr Speaker, to that end, I will respectfully refer the House to the House of Commons, the Parliament of Great Britain, which is said to be the mother of all Parliaments. Mr Speaker, in 1945, when Prime Minister Winston Churchill lost to the opposition leader, Clement Attlee, he had been in Parliament for several terms. But Prime Minister Winston Churchill, having been booted out of government, moved from the very first Frontbench to the Backbench. He became a Backbencher.

Mr Speaker, Theresa May, I believe, even up till now, is still in the House of Commons. She was a former Prime Minister; she is a Backbencher. Mr Speaker, the leader of the opposition for

a long time, Jeremy Corbyn, leader of the Labour Party, was a Frontbencher like the former Minority Leader Haruna Iddrisu, and many others. When he was no longer the Leader of the Opposition, he became a Backbencher.

Mr Speaker, the problem we have here is that—So, for example, Hon Haruna Iddrisu was in Parliament in 2005. He became Minister for Communication in 2009. By this definition, at the time, he was a Backbencher. Mr Speaker, there are advantages for our system—*[Interruption]*. Yes, he was.

Mr Speaker, I see my big Brother—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Can you read the definition in the Standing Order?

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, let me read the definition.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Because it is not only using the number of times one is in Parliament.

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, let me read it. I am saying that he came into Parliament in 2005. In 2009, he was a second-term. If he were not a Minister in 2009, by this definition, he would be a Backbencher.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, you are now talking, but that was not what you said initially.

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, I am saying that by this definition, if he were

not a Minister for Communication in 2009, he would be a Backbencher.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, now you are correct, but initially you were wrong.

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, I am guided. But the point I am making is that the contribution from the Minister for Education about learning would have meant that if we were practising the British system, a first-timer could be seated right here behind the pillar and seated by a former Prime Minister, a former Minister or a former ranking member.

Mr Speaker, so there is something in my view, respectfully, anomalous with the definition of Backbencher, which is tied up solely to the term of office—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** No, that is why you are wrong. Read the definition carefully.

**Mr S. A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, if I can conclude. The definition of Backbencher is tied up to the term of office, to leadership and to ministerial portfolio. No, but in Britain, in the House of Commons, Mr Speaker, a Backbencher is tied up to either being a member of the shadow government or being a member of His Majesty's government.

The question about the term of office arises solely on account of who is the father of the House. Term of office does not come in when it comes to being a Backbencher or Frontbencher. Mr Speaker, being a Frontbencher or a

Backbencher is tied up to either being a member of the government or a member of the shadow government. One's role in government or role in opposition.

Mr Speaker, that is why, for example, the 1922 Committee, which is a Backbench Committee, is arguably one of the most powerful committees in the Conservative Party in the House of Commons, which, even in many cases, is capable of toppling the Prime Minister. So, the point is that, yes, the point has been made that we give Backbenchers the opportunity and so on and so forth.

But my view is, and I want to conclude on that, and I am not here to question the Standing Orders, but perhaps we should take a cue from the Minister for Education in further interrogating the provisions of this Standing Order. If we are actually going to be in a position where first-timers or second-timers get the opportunity to contribute and represent fully in this House, we may have to look at the definition of Backbenchers again. And perhaps, take inspiration from the mother of all Parliaments.

But Mr Speaker, while I have the opportunity, former President Akufo-Addo, never—

4:11 p.m.

He never apologised nor said anything to the effect that the debt overhang was something he did as a President or his Government did—What he sought to say—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Were you there with them?

**Mr S.A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, this is a House of records.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon former Minister, were you there with them?

The current Minister for Education made reference to him meeting the President outside and the conversation between them.

**Mr S.A. Jinapor:** No, he said the former President said something at a conference in Brussels. He said he made the point publicly in Brussels. What the former President said was that, that was his darkest moment but that it was absolutely necessary and further said it is the reason why we are enjoying some relative stability in the macro-economic sector of our country. That is what the former President said. What the Minister of Education said was totally misleading. Thank you very much Mr Speaker for the opportunity.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Minister for Energy and Green Transition.

**Mr John A. Jinapor:** Mr Speaker, whether Mohammed went to the mountain or the mountain went to Mohammed, at least there are some movements and whether Jonah swallowed the whale or the whale swallowed Jonah, there is a swallow.

Mr Speaker, this is a very interesting topic, and I find it very intriguing.

Indeed, listening to my Hon Colleagues, I am very happy and proud to be a Member of this Parliament. It is true that in the British Parliament, tenure of office is not the major determining factor of whether you are a Frontbencher or a Backbencher. But in the British Parliament, the opposition side mirrors the government side because it is a Westminster system. So as much as the person is a minister, that person is a Member of Parliament. That is why you see shadow minister, but here we do not use shadow minister. Can you imagine placing the Hon Haruna Iddrisu, as experienced as he is, in the Backbench row in Ghana's Parliament? That is why every parliament is shaped by its culture, ethics and practices. So, if we determine that having somebody like the Hon Haruna Iddrisu, having spent all these numbers of years here, he should—Twenty-one years. If you were a lady, you should be getting ready to get married at 21. *[Laughter]* That is real experience. So, can you imagine putting the Hon Haruna Iddrisu in the category of Backbench? It cannot work. So, I find wisdom in deciding that the tenure of office or one's years of experience ought to determine where they sit. Even in this Parliament, when we are doing sitting arrangements, one's years of experience count a lot. I think that we should not discount that at all.

I can only relate to Mr Haruna Iddrisu. When I entered here as a first-timer, a lot of people thought I had stayed here for some time. It was because people like Haruna Iddrisu mentored us, and not only mentored us but they gave us the opportunity to speak. For me, that

is critical. On very critical matters, if it is for four people, they will pick three Frontbenchers and add a Backbencher. He would sit with you, walk you through, and show you how to speak. For me, that is more practical and efficient because if you allocate a day and say this day is for Backbenchers, like Dr Abdul Kabiru Tiah Mahama said, it connotes a certain mentality.

Mr Speaker, you may, as you want to guide us, but I would only appeal to Leadership and to yourself, that even as we debate the key issues, once in a while you can identify a Backbencher—I recall Prof Aaron Mike Oquaye, anytime we spoke, Mr Adongo and I, he would invite us to his office and encourage us. This is because he believed in in-depth knowledge analysis. Sometimes even when he is giving you three minutes, and he realises that you are churning out facts, and quoting, he would give you extra two minutes and say that this is bonus for exhibiting knowledge and a sense of maturity.

Mr Speaker, let me thank you for giving me this opportunity. We are still learning. This Parliament has been around for a while. We will continue to learn from people like you. I do not think that we need to change the current rendition of who is a Backbencher but I think that it is the approach and how we go about it that we should tinker with. On this note, Mr Speaker, I want to thank you for the opportunity.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you. Yes, Hon Leaders?

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu (NPP — Tolon):** Thank you, Mr Speaker, for the opportunity to also add my voice and comment on the Statement made by the Chairman of the Backbenchers' Committee.

Mr Speaker, I think we are all saying the same thing, except that we are mixing up the United Kingdom (UK) system and the Ghana system. The UK is running the opposition and government form of parliament. We in Ghana have the Majority and the Minority form of legislation. In essence, it means that in Ghana, you can be majority and it will not only be one party that forms the majority. It could be a combination of parties to form a Majority. Just as what happened in the Eighth Parliament, where we, the NPP Majority had 137, our colleagues in the NDC had 137, but the Independent Members elected to do business with us for us thus forming the Majority Party in the Parliament. So, trying to actually compare in terms of the parliamentary systems of Ghana and the UK would be very difficult.

Some Hon Members were making statements to the effect that many MPs entered the Chamber as Backbenchers; it is not everybody who entered Parliament as a Backbencher. I was fortunate; I did not enter this Chamber as a Backbencher. I entered this Parliament as a Leader of this House. So, people are fortunate and are lucky to be able to learn and have the opportunity to do so many things. But this Parliament—Especially with the Minority Side, we are very unique. For instance, when Mr Abu Jinapor entered Parliament, he entered as a Minister. So, when you read Order 6 of our Standing

Orders on interpretation, it is clear that as a Minister, he was not—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** That may be applicable to you, but that is not applicable to a minister.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, if you read the interpretation—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** The day of entry, you were made a Leader, but he entered before he was appointed as a Minister. So, he did not enter the way you entered.

**Mr Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I am guided. Hon Minister for Energy and Green Transition, you entered as a Backbencher. I did not enter as a Backbencher. So, allow me to make my point—*[Interruption]*. I am your Leader.

Mr Speaker, even though Dr Kabiru Mahama tried mentioning many other names, you could see that some of our first-time MPs, especially on the Minority Side, hardly would you be able to identify that they are even first-timers or Backbenchers when they are on their feet. The quality of their debates, the depth of analysis that they make when they are—Mr Speaker, at a point, the Majority agreed with the quality of the Minority. That is why the Hon Majority Leader proposed that we should allow three of them to speak and one of us will speak because he knew the quality we had on our Side. So, Mr Speaker, this Statement made by the Chairman of the Backbenchers' Committee—But I want to call on him that he has every power under our Standing Order, Order 236—It

has given him the power under Standing Order 236, and if he—

Mr Speaker, because it says that they must determine one— that is Order 236 (2), that “The Committee shall (a) determine the business of Backbenchers for each Meeting”. So, if he sits down with his Committee Members, they can determine what they want to do. They can propose the business for the Backbenchers, the time and order in which the business shall be taken, and relate with the Business Committee. I would want to remind him that within the Standing Orders, he has some powers as to what he is seeking, even though this Statement is very important.

We have a lot of people here, the Minister for Education who is a former Leader just left, they can guide and inspire. That is why when you see that those who are on our Side, the first-timers, when they get up, I call them ‘sharpshooters’. Mr Speaker, you would see that one of our Minority first-timers will make a Statement or contribute to a debate and it will take close to ten of the Majority to make a Statements that will be equivalent to that of the quality that we have and the nurturing that we enjoy. Mr Speaker, what we have been able to do and successfully done is that—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Mr Habib Iddrisu, you have been in this House for some time, and then you are a Leader, and you must be guided as such.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I am guided and I will depart from where I was going, except to add that the quality

of the Members of the Minority Caucus is very solid.

4.21 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Seniors, Hon Kojo Oppong Nkrumah, Hon S. Jinapor and the others have Members who are First-timers that they are nurturing, guiding and showing how to debate. I do not think our Colleagues on the other Side are doing that. Because they are too many, they do not even have time for their Colleagues. But our Side has the quality to be able to guide our Colleagues —

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** — *rose* —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Yes, Hon Zanetor?

**Dr Agyeman-Rawlings:** I am rising on a point of order. I do not think that it is accurate, to be quite honest. The Leader is misleading the House, because to say that we on the Majority Side are not mentoring is presumptuous and wrong, so, he should kindly correct himself. If he knows of anyone who is not mentoring somebody else, he should feel free to say so, but he should not generalise. It is wrong to do so.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I think Hon “Zanator” — *[Laughter]* — Zanator? All right, Mr Speaker “Zainab”—

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Habib, with all due respect, having regard to your position as Frontbench, some statements ought not to come from you only for them to be taken on a point



of order. That is why I am providing a guide to you. Leadership has a way of speaking on the Floor of Parliament.

**Alhaji Habib Iddrisu:** Mr Speaker, I am guided. In fact, I was speaking about the quality of my MPs. I know my Side; I cannot speak for the Majority. Mr Speaker, with these few words, I think this Statement is important, and I call on the Chairman of the Committee to do more so that he will be able to come out with programmes and workshops to enhance the capacity of his Members.

I thank you, Mr Speaker.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Members, before giving the floor to the Deputy Majority Leader, let me indicate that when I came to Parliament, I learnt a lot from the Front. Let me also state that sometimes we take things lightly, other than that, certain things that we say on the Floor of Parliament can be a subject matter of privileges under our own Standing Orders. So, please, let us all be guided, and we need to speak with that guidance in mind.

Yes, Deputy Majority Leader? —

**Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib:** I am very much aware that my boss has spoken, so there would not be the platform. But since it is just an engagement for Members, I just pray that you permit me to make a very —

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, I am taking one each from Leadership. So, once he has spoken — You know the rules, so, once you know them —

**Mr Shaib:** Mr Speaker, you always indulge us.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** I owe fidelity to the law. So, Deputy Majority Leader, you have the floor.

**Deputy Majority Leader (Mr George Kweku Ricketts-Hagan):** Thank you very much, Mr Speaker. I want to take the opportunity to congratulate — Actually, two Statements were made, and Leadership did not get to comment on them. We were talking about the last one, but there was actually a first Statement that was made by Hon Zanetor Agyeman-Rawlings, and the other Statement made by the Chairman of the Committee on Backbenchers' Business. So, I want to take the opportunity to thank them for both Statements made.

Mr Speaker, all these things we are talking about, Backbenchers and all that, are mostly British legacy which we have copied, adopted and upgraded. We can define what our own Backbenchers should be, and that is what we have done. What I noticed is that in our Standing Orders, what we have as a function — if we look at page 133, where the function of the Committee on Backbenchers is given, much is not actually there. This is because apart from these functions we have here with all the new Committees we have put in the Standing Orders, we have not actually developed the manuals that go with this Committee to know exactly what a Backbencher should be doing. So, I think we should speed up on these manuals for Backbenchers to know what their functions are, and then, of

course, the definitions we have provided here on who a Backbencher is.

But I think, importantly, it is what the Backbencher is supposed to do. They are actually supposed to also be learning from us, the Leaders or those who have been here. So, the things we do and say are things that are taken up by the Backbenchers to develop what they will eventually become. So, as you have rightly directed, I think we should be very careful on the things that we say so that our Backbenchers do not pick the wrong signals or the wrong things to do.

On the second one, which has to do with the maritime security matter that the Hon Member raised, I think that is an important one. It is quite alarming that we have this maritime crime going on, involving piracy and all that, but as a country, whether they are standalone laws or the ones we have in some conventions, we have not even adopted them well, and our standalone ones cannot stand the test of time. It is important to note the recommendations my Hon Sister has given for the Minister for Transport to quickly come with a Bill to upgrade the old laws we have that are not functioning, so that we can upgrade these things.

There is also a lot of technology out there which is being used in the fight against maritime crime in terms of maritime security. This is because maritime crime is not only about the security aspect, but there is also an economic and defence risk, therefore it is important that we bring our laws and the

technology to fight these things up to speed. We also need to engage the communities which are usually within the fishing areas to be well educated and aware of what is going on around them, so that we can defend our frontiers as we should do as a country.

Mr Speaker, with these few words, I would like to end here.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Thank you very much.

Hon Members, when I declined the request of the Deputy Minority Whip, there was uproar. It is for a stated reason that a chief will always speak last. There is a reason why Leaders speak last. When there is a mistake from behind you, the Leader can intervene and correct that particular mistake. So, after giving the opportunity to the Leader to speak, you do not open the floor for any other person behind him to also speak; that is reason.

So, it is not proper that after giving the Leader the opportunity to speak, you go and give the floor to a person behind him to also speak. We as Speakers are guided by some of those things. So, it is not that you have a discretion to give and you are refusing to give that particular discretion. So, Hon Members, those who do not know should take it from now that if you are even up and somebody from your Frontbench is up to speak, I cannot ignore the person in front, that is the senior, to recognise you at the back. So, all these things must guide us as Members of Parliament.

Hon Members, Statement time has ended. Deputy Majority Leader, any indication?

4.31 p.m.

**Mr Ricketts-Hagan:** Mr Speaker, we have been here for less than five hours, so we are in your hands.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Well, less than five hours, you have to move a Motion under Standing Order 156.

**Mr Ricketts-Hagan:** Sorry, Mr Speaker. I move that this House adjourns till tomorrow 2 o'clock.

**Mr First Deputy Speaker:** Hon Shaib?

**Mr Jerry Ahmed Shaib:** Mr Speaker, the Motion is seconded, except that from the Side of the 189 Members, we can see 32 Members.

*Question put and Motion agreed to.*

## ADJOURNMENT

*The House was accordingly adjourned till Thursday, 23<sup>rd</sup> October, 2025 at 2 o'clock in the afternoon.*

## **Editor's Note**

This Official Report was corrected by the House on 29th October, 2025 as follows:

- (a) Column 3, paragraph 1, line 2, “ecause” was corrected to “because”
- (b) Column 38, paragraph 5, line 6, “know” was replaced with “note”